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Formas' CoARA Action Plan Report 2022–2027

The following report describes completed and ongoing development work, including monitoring and evaluation, carried out in relation to the commitments within CoARA. The work is ongoing and may include further activities. The plan will therefore be updated over time.

Formas – a research council for sustainable development

Formas is a public research council for sustainable development. We fund research and innovation, develop strategies, carry out analyses and evaluations. Our areas of activity include the environment, agricultural sciences and spatial planning. We produce evidence-based analyses that help Sweden achieve its environmental goals. We also communicate research and research results.

Examples of Formas' other tasks are to make use of research results and to promote sustainable development in society. Among other things, Formas funds research and innovation related to climate, the circular economy, food, agriculture, forestry and urban planning. The research is often interdisciplinary and carried out in close cooperation with many different social actors.

Formas signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) in November 2021 and joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA).

For questions about this report and CoARA-related activities at Formas, please contact:

Lissa Nordin, Lissa.nordin@formas.se

Formas' previous commitments, roles and positions in relation to commitments within CoARA

- Formas signed the DORA statement in 2018 and shortly thereafter implemented changes to the instructions for the research review process. Reviewers, appointed by Formas, will not use Journal Impact Factors (JIF) or H-index when assessing the quality of applications.
- Formas has a strong commitment to Open Science and has been a member of the COAlition S since its inception. Formas has developed a policy on open access to publications based on the principles of Plan S (1 January 2021).
- Formas' appropriation directions require the agency to continue its work on gender mainstreaming, so that our activities can contribute to achieving national policy goals for gender equality. To enable this work, Formas has developed a Gender Mainstreaming Strategy for the years 2022–2025. The strategy contains three main objectives and examples of initiatives to achieve them. [Formas strategi för jämställdhetsintegrering eng-GB.pdf](#)

- In 2021, Formas decided to introduce seven basic principles on which our funding and evaluation process should be based, taken from the Global Research Council (2018), "Statement of Principles on Peer/Merit Review". The principles are: *Expert judgement, Openness and transparency, Impartiality, Appropriateness, Confidentiality and professional secrecy, Integrity and ethics, Equality, equity and diversity*. [Funding - Formas](#)

Participation in CoARA

National level

- Formas supports the Swedish National Chapter presented by the Association of Swedish Higher Education Institutions (SUHF) and participates in the work tasks that are arranged within the national framework. [CoARA National Chapter Sweden – CoARA](#)

European level

- Formas is a member of the COAlition S Expert Group and a participant in the Leader's Group.
- Formas is actively involved in discussions with the European Commission, Science Europe and other committed organisations to support the funding and development of Open Research Europe, ORE, publishing platform. A Statement of Intent on Open Research Europe was signed by Formas and other organisations in December 2024.
- Formas is a member of Science Europe's Working Groups on Open Science and Research Culture and is represented in Science Europe's High Level Policy Network.

International/Global Level

- Formas is a member (and co-chair) of the sub-group on transdisciplinary research assessment in the CoARA working group Towards Transformations: Transdisciplinarity, Applied/Practice-Based Research and Impact. [WG Towards Transformations: Transdisciplinarity, Applied/Practice-Based Research, and Impacts – CoARA](#)
- Formas participates in meetings organised by the Global Research Council and in discussions on global standards for research funding, including responsible research assessment.

CoARA commitments and the work of Formas

The CoARA agreement is based on several measures and principles for assessment and qualification. These include the following:

- Valuing a diversity of scholarly contributions and careers
- Base research assessments primarily on qualitative evaluation, supported by the responsible use of quantitative indicators

- Avoid the inappropriate use of journal and publication-based metrics in research assessment, particularly the inappropriate use of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
- Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.

Most of these actions have already been implemented in the past, in the context of our signing of the DORA Declaration.

The focus of our work during the Action Plan period will be to further develop our research funding system in line with the principles of CoARA. This includes valuing open science practices, including collaborative research and different forms of cooperation; recognising the diversity of research activities, roles and practices; ensuring gender equality and equal opportunities within research teams; and integrating these aspects into the content of research. Actions will include reviewing and developing criteria, tools and procedures, communicating on developed assessments and providing support for the use of new procedures.

Launching two new calls and new processes for advancing research assessments

In 2023–2024 (and ongoing), we have developed two new calls, the “Career Grant for Early-career Researchers” [Career Grant for Early-career Researchers - Formas](#) and “Explore” [Explore – Formas’ open call - Formas](#). As part of this development work, and in line with our commitments from CoARA, we looked at how a CV could be designed that better allows for a diversity of applicants’ qualifications and contributions. This resulted in a new and narrative CV format, called the Academic Profile. The new CV format was piloted in both the Career Grant and Explore calls.

The academic profile allows the applicant to describe in a more narrative way their experiences and competences – and how these are relevant to the project in question. The decision to use a narrative CV format and the design of the template for this purpose were based on the following considerations:

- Formas funds research in several different disciplines and research areas. Different disciplines and fields of research produce different types of results, have different ways of publishing, and have different merit systems. To create a level playing field, applicants must be able to decide for themselves which experiences, contributions and merits they wish to highlight, and in what order.
- The ongoing movement for - and transition to - an open science system requires new types of scientific evaluation that consider all kinds of outcomes and contributions that research and innovation can bring. These could be, for example, different types of publications, knowledge dissemination and education, open data, patents, policy contributions or other forms of impact. The applicant must therefore be able to describe a variety of outcomes and contributions, in equal ways.
- The competence of the project participants must be assessed in relation to the project applied for. The applicant must therefore be able to describe and justify how the stated experience, contributions and merits are relevant to the project applied for.

The aim of this development work is to develop the evaluation of applications in a way that better reflects the diversity of scientific contributions and careers, and that values different practices in

open science. A new CV format supports this by allowing applicants to better describe and justify the contributions they wish to highlight in relation to the project they are applying for.

To further incentivise contributions to open science and to recognise the diversity of research outputs, we have also included open science and science communication as one of the evaluation criteria for the Explore call. Our intention is, after careful follow-up and evaluation of the effects of the introduced developments and changes in the pilot calls, to implement narrative CV and criteria for open science in all Formas calls for research funding, starting from 2026 and onwards.

Ongoing development and implementation, monitoring and evaluation

We are constantly monitoring and adapting the pilot calls and their processes and evaluating other initiatives that are important for the development of our research funding system.

This is particularly important as we need to further develop and adjust the calls so that the introduced changes work optimally. We also need to take on the lessons learned to be able to introduce changes on a broad front in our funding process.

To help us do this, we have an analysis and evaluation plan with deadlines for analysis and evaluation. The figure below summarises the development work specifically related to the CoARA principles and commitments:

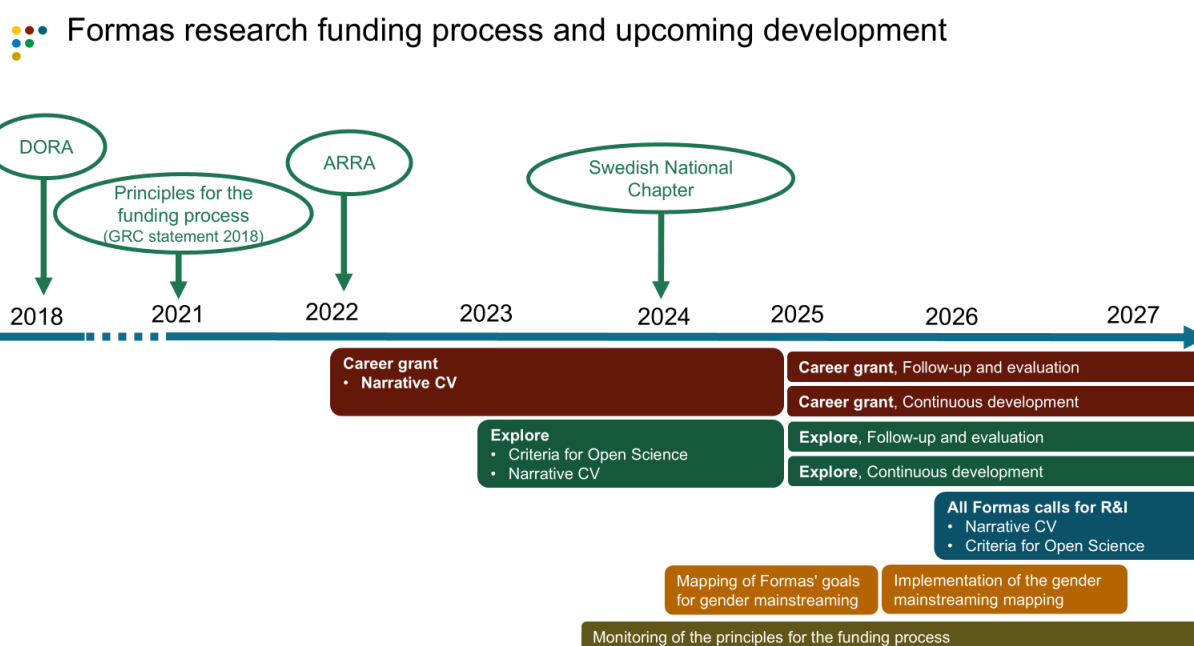


Figure 1. Formas research funding process and upcoming development.